

CORE FORMULA

Context -> Action -> Result -> Learning -> Context: what the situation was. **Action:** what you did. **Result:** what happened. **Learning:** what you took from it. -> **Worked:** "The launch was slipping. I cut scope to the core feature. We shipped on time. I now agree the must-haves up front." -> **Minimum viable move:** Context: X. Action: Y. Result: Z. Learning: L. -> **Best field rule:** use the structure to organise thought, then speak like a person.

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Silently order your point as Context, Action, Result, Learning, then say it in four plain sentences without ever naming the framework.

BEST FOR

- Reflection and debriefs after an event
- Supervision and development conversations
- Interviews and competency-style answers
- Learning stories where the lesson is the whole point
- Making a spoken contribution concise and memorable
- Written updates the reader needs to scan quickly

PHRASE BANK

Quick framing · One-line openers

- "Quick version: here's what happened, what I did, and what I took from it."
- "Short one — context, action, result, learning."
- "Let me keep this to four beats."
- "Give me thirty seconds and I'll walk it through."
- "Here's the situation, then what I did about it."
- "In brief: the setup, the move, the outcome, the lesson."
- "One example, quickly."

Warm reflection · Sharing a learning story

- "Honestly, here's what I took from it."
- "The thing I learned has stuck with me."
- "It didn't go to plan, and that's the useful part."
- "Looking back, I'd do one thing differently."
- "I'm still glad I tried it, even though it wobbled."
- "What changed for me was small but real."
- "That one taught me more than the wins did."

Meetings and written updates · Work and email

- "Context: where we were. Action: what we changed. Result: what shifted. Learning: what we'll carry forward."
- "Here's the situation, what we did, the outcome, and the takeaway."
- "I'll set the scene, then the decision, then the result."
- "The headline is the result; the rest is background."
- "For the update: what happened, our response, where it landed."
- "Let me label these so you can scan them."
- "The learning we're taking into the next cycle is this."

- "One short paragraph each: context, action, result, learning."

Getting to the point · Cutting to the core

- "The main point is X; the rest is only support."
- "Bottom line first, then the story behind it."
- "Here's what I'd do differently next time."
- "The result was Y, and here's why."
- "I'll give you the lesson, then the evidence for it."
- "Skip to the learning — this is what changes now."
- "One clean next step out of all of this."

When it lands badly · Softening and recovery

- "I made that too structured — let me say it more simply."
- "That may not be the useful frame. Let me back up."
- "I don't want the structure to override the actual issue."
- "What part of that was useful, and what should we drop?"
- "Let me drop the scaffolding and just tell you what happened."
- "I got a bit formulaic there — one plain sentence instead."

Sensitive or high-pressure moments · Check before structuring

- "Before I frame this — is a structured version helpful, or would you rather just talk it through?"
- "I can lay this out clearly, but I want to hear you first."
- "Let me check whether that structure is useful or if we should approach it another way."
- "I'll keep this to one sentence per step, then pause."
- "This one's heavy — tell me if the structure is getting in the way."
- "One line each, and stop me whenever."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Announces the framework and recites every step.
Better: Uses CARL silently to organise a concise answer.
Best: Moves through it so lightly it just sounds like clear thinking.
2. Weak: Ends on a vague lesson that changes nothing.
Better: Names a real, specific learning.
Best: Names the learning and what it changes next time.
3. Weak: Pushes the structure harder when the listener looks lost.
Better: Notices and simplifies.
Best: Drops the frame and checks what the listener actually needs.

DECISION TREE

If The listener needs speed

Use the shortest version — result first, one line each.
"Bottom line: we shipped on time. Quick why, if it's useful."

If The listener needs support

Validate first; delay the framework until the emotion settles.
"That sounds like it was a lot. Want me to lay it out, or just talk it through?"

If The listener needs a story or example

Walk the four beats as a narrative, not as labels.
"Let me tell you how that one actually went."

If The listener needs to act

End with one clean next step.
"So the next step is a scope check at kickoff."

If The listener looks confused

Summarise and invite correction rather than pushing the structure harder.

"Let me boil that down — did I make the point or muddy it?"

SCENARIOS

Work meeting

Make one contribution concise and memorable — four beats, no labels. — "Here's the situation, what we did, where it landed, and what we'll carry forward."

Written update or email

Put each step in a short labelled paragraph so the reader can scan it. — "Context: ... Action: ... Result: ... Learning: ..."

Feedback conversation

Check what kind of feedback is wanted before you structure anything. — "Would it help if I walked through what happened and what I'd change?"

Job interview or competency answer

Answer in four beats, end on the learning, then invite the follow-up. — "The result was we shipped on time; the learning was to agree the must-haves early."

Difficult conversation

One sentence per step, then pause and let them respond. — "Here's what happened. Here's what I did. Here's where it left us."

Debrief after something went wrong

Keep blame out of it and make the learning the point. — "Less about who — more about what we now know for next time."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- You need a direct recommendation, not a reflection
- Reflection would sound self-protective or like an excuse
- Emotion is high and listening or validation should come first
- There is shame, grief, anger or a real power imbalance
- The decision is high-stakes and needs a straight answer
- Physical safety or an emergency takes priority

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Write it out

Take a real experience and write a 60-second response using Context -> Action -> Result -> Learning.

Day 2 — Cut it down

Cut yesterday's response by a third — down to about 30 seconds — without losing the core point.

Day 3 — Sharpen the learning

Rewrite the Learning line so it names something specific that would change what you do next time; delete any "I learned a lot."

Day 4 — Two voices

Say it aloud twice — once as a visible structure with labels, once as plain speech. Notice how much better the plain version lands.

Day 5 — Serve the listener

For your response, ask: would this help the other person understand, decide or act? Trim anything that only makes you sound polished.

Day 6 — Practise a recovery

Rehearse one recovery line so you can drop the scaffolding smoothly if it lands badly — e.g. "I made that too structured; let me say it more simply."

Day 7 — Use it live

In one real conversation, use CARL silently — four plain sentences, never named — and watch whether the listener becomes clearer.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I use CARL to serve the listener, not to sound polished?
- Was the core point clear?
- Did I keep it concise?
- Was the learning specific enough to change next time?
- Did I adapt when the listener needed something else?
- Did I preserve the other person's autonomy and dignity?